

Limelight's first production of Absurdist Theatre

RHINOCEROS

BY EUGENE IONESCO

Directed by Mary Claire Branton



May 30 -
June 15

Lime **LIGHT**
THEATRE

"Rhinceros" is presented by arrangement with Concord Theatricals on behalf of Samuel French, Inc. www.concordtheatricals.com

FROM THE EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR



Years ago, *Rhinoceros* was the play that I used to teach my Theatre Appreciation students all about Absurdist theatre. I grew to love it because of the crazy way it ultimately delivers a message of hope. It will take you down a dark path, riddled with both rational and irrational logic, but ultimately is meant to inspire strength of purpose and identity.

In Ionesco’s *Rhinoceros*, people begin to morph away from humanity when there is a failure to understand true identity, and when they become uncertain of their individual purpose. Clarity of identity is the only safe foundation, but weakness of character leaves vulnerability to change, out of a need for security and inclusion. Ultimately, to stand alone in one’s independent, individual identity is lonely, and only for those willing to be brave, bold, and hopeful in what is unseen.

What is your identity and purpose? I hope *Rhinoceros* will remind you to not get distracted, but maintain your humanity, despite a growing movement to dehumanize us all!

Thank you for coming to see *Rhinoceros* and supporting the Limelight Theatre!

-Sherrie Provence, Executive Director of the Limelight Theatre

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Director's Note



Virtually anything can happen in a theatre due to suspension of disbelief. This is the strength and infinity of the medium. Our concept for *Rhinoceros* is cognizant of transhumanism, where AI and robotics redefine and implement a post-human earth. Yet, we focus upon 1959, when these words were clicked onto ink ribbons from the brilliant mind of the Father of Absurdist Theatre, Eugène Ionesco.

“Justification” is an important debate introduced through his dialogue. People justify absurd and evil behavior all the time using logic. Nazi Germany lost its humanity by killing more than six million Jews. Other cults, terrorist groups, and most tyrannical movements all justify themselves with twisted logic. We are currently losing our humanity through AI dictating our lives through algorithms, destroying the livelihood of artists and writers. In essence, this is the redesigning of human DNA.

Humanity is *precious*. Our individuality is the mark of a Creator. Human extinction is the real end, even if our species decides to upload our brains to computers in order to live forever in cyberspace. That’s not living. To swim in rivers and oceans is living. Long walks in the park, reading books, first kisses, procreating, finding friendship, and studying nature. What is living to you? Hopefully you don’t have to consult ChatGPT to figure it out. It’s a grand earth, and all’s a stage. Would you alter your DNA for a new existence? Personally, I’d like to keep sharing the one thing that makes all of us equal.

Absurdism is frequently associated with pessimism and atheistic tendencies, hinting that life is meaningless. Ionesco was a true pioneer. He proclaims there is great meaning in being human on this earth. He also believed in an afterlife, having it carved on his gravestone for us to pray to the “I don’t know who - Jesus Christ, I hope.”

Even through absurdism, Ionesco offered hope. Through our production, I hope everyone sees the importance of theatre and supports organizations that struggle to the very end to keep human art alive.

After explaining our concept to the cast, I admitted, “I don’t know if anyone has ever staged *Rhinoceros* like this.”

One actress responded, “Maybe no one ever *needed* to.”



Cast

ALBERTO CARLOS PEART.....	BERENGER
NICOLE MAAHS.....	DAISY
COLLIN JAMES.....	JEAN
TREVOR KLUCKMAN.....	DUDARD
MICHAEL GALE.....	BOTARD
NICHOLAS FROST.....	MR PAPILLON
DOLORES GENDE.....	MRS BOEUF
HANNAH SCHAEFER.....	LOGICIAN
AMELIA GALE.....	OLD GENTLEMAN
MEGAN RODRIGUEZ.....	HOUSEWIFE WITH CAT
ANTHONY ROMERO.....	GROCER / FIREMAN
EMILY PANEK.....	GROCER'S WIFE / WAITRESS
CHARLES ROSS.....	PROPRIETOR / FIREMAN

Crew

Director.....	Mary Claire Branton
Assistant Director.....	Audrey Hoffman
Stage Manager.....	Millie McKinney
Dramaturg.....	Emily Layt
Set Design.....	Robert O'Leary
Light Design.....	Michael Takita
Assistant Light Design.....	Day Stanchi
Costume Design.....	Jamie Bullins
Costumers.....	Janice Bickel & Lois Dent
Armband Design.....	Rachel Mills
Makeup.....	Olivia Ferreira
Mask Design.....	Jenn Michael
Properties Design.....	Rod Morris
Paint Charge.....	Sue Schwartz
Construction.....	Don Cupo, Charles Ross, Robert O'Leary
Music.....	Megan Rodriguez
Film / Sound Design.....	Nicholas Frost
Publicity Trailer.....	Nicholas Frost
Show Trailer.....	Julieta Ramos Correa
Fight Director / Bed Intimacy Choreography.....	Ryan Mahannah
Light Board Operator.....	Don Cupo, Matthew Rodriguez
Technical Director.....	Don Cupo
Publicity.....	Lacey Cataleta

Amelia Cale



Amelia (Old Gentleman) is 11 years old and discovered her love for action in 2024 when she landed her first role as Gloria in Limelight's production of *WAIT UNTIL DARK*. Since then, she has performed in four shows, making this her fifth production and her third with Limelight. In her free time, Amelia enjoys creating art and traveling. She especially loves acting alongside her dad and other adults, as she finds they tend to be more focused and easier to work with than kids.

Michael Cale



Michael (Botard) began acting in 2024, alongside his daughter, Amelia. A lifelong theatre enthusiast, he finally took the leap and has now completed five shows in just one year. Michael started with a small role in *WAIT UNTIL DARK*, followed by *PETER PAN*, and then moved into leading roles in *MEMOIRS OF A FORGOTTEN MAN* and *A DICKENS CAROL*. He is thrilled to be part of another production and looks forward to the new challenges it brings. Limelight is like a second family to Michael and loves

performing there. Michael is happily married, has a stepchild Andrew who is graduating 2025 and his everything Amelia who is 11 years old and in sixth grade at Pacetti Bay. This will be the 4th show that he is in with his daughter and is loving every minute of it.

Nicholas Frost



Nicholas (Papillon) is a Florida native who grew up in Shakespeare-rich Ashland, OR. Nicholas performed in productions ranging from *THE ODD COUPLE* to *TWELFTH NIGHT* and *WAITING FOR GODOT*. At Southern Oregon University, he studied film production, created short films, and produced local audio dramas, including *THE HITCHHIKER'S GUIDE TO THE GALAXY*. After many years away from live theater, Nicholas returns in Limelight Theatre's *RHINOCEROS*—his first stage production since university. Now managing a St. Augustine tour guide cooperative

(thanks to his signature curly mustache landing him the gig) Nicholas finds this absurdist masterpiece increasingly relevant. This play in this nation at this moment has more meaning than ever.

**“GREAT THEATRE IS ABOUT CHALLENGING HOW
WE THINK AND ENCOURAGING US TO
FANTASIZE ABOUT A WORLD WE ASPIRE TO.”**

-WILLEM DAFOE

*Thank you for supporting community theatre.
Ned & Paula Skinner*

Cast

Dolores Cende



Dolores (Mrs. Boeuf) is excited to return to the stage at Limelight Theatre after playing Mother/Teacher/Peasant in *MEMOIRS OF A FORGOTTEN MAN* last summer. Her theater journey began in the 1980s at the American Theater of Guadalajara, where she took on roles in acting, dancing, and stage management. Since moving to St. Augustine, Dolores has performed with Cascades Players Club in *HONEYMOON AT GRAVESIDE MANOR*, *DEATH AND TAXES*, and *THE CLOCK STRUCK ONE*.

She has also contributed as an assistant director. She is deeply grateful to Director Mary Claire Branton for the opportunity to be part of this thought-provoking production and extends heartfelt thanks to her husband for his unwavering support.

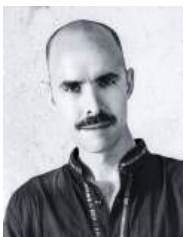
Collin James



Collin (Jean) is excited to be joining this amazing cast and crew in such an absurd and delightful production. He is a graduate of Florida School of the Arts, where he majored in Acting. Collin was last seen on the Limelight stage as Feldzieg in *THE DROWSY CHAPERONE*. He has performed in numerous productions across Florida, taking on roles such as Radar O'Reilly in *MASH**, Charlie Brown in *YOU'RE A GOOD MAN, CHARLIE BROWN*, Silvio in *THE SERVANT OF TWO MASTERS*, and

Simon Bright in *THE GAME'S AFOOT: HOLMES FOR THE HOLIDAYS*, among many others. Collin is incredibly grateful to everyone at Limelight Theatre for their warm welcome and continued encouragement. He looks forward to collaborating with the many creative individuals who make Limelight such a special place.

Trevor Kluckman



Trevor (Dudard) is delighted to make his Limelight debut in *RHINOCEROS*. Originally from Aberdeen, Scotland, he holds a Bachelor of Arts from Marymount Manhattan College. New York City credits include Tennessee Williams' *THE PINK BEDROOM* (Theatre Row), directed by Matthew Lillard; Mark Antony in *JULIUS CAESAR* (Hudson Warehouse); *WHERE'S MY MONEY?* (Cherry Lane Theatre); and *MADISON SCARE GARDEN* (Theatre at Madison Square Garden). Regional credits include

VENUS IN FUR and *MACBETH* (Wolfbane Productions), and *MOTHERS AND SONS* (A Classic Theatre). On screen, Trevor has appeared on ABC's *ONE LIFE TO LIVE* and in the indie romcom *APRIL FLOWERS*, available on Apple TV.

Cast

Nicole Maahs



Nicole (Daisy) is delighted to bring Daisy to life! She holds a Bachelor of Fine Arts in Acting from Florida State University. Nicole was most recently seen as Lucy Steele in Limelight Theatre's *SENSE AND SENSIBILITY*, in *SHAKESBEER* with Lumen Rep, as Algernon in Limelight's staged reading of *THE IMPORTANCE OF BEING EARNEST*, and as Hippolyta in Pursued By A Bear's *A MIDSUMMER NIGHT'S DREAM*. She is deeply grateful for the love and support of her family and sends kisses to her beloved sons, Alexander and Rowan!

Emily Panek



Emily Panek is a lifelong resident of St. Augustine, FL, and a sophomore at St. Augustine High School. She is an active member of the St. Johns County Center for the Arts, participating in its theatre, musical theatre, and chorus programs. Most recently, she appeared as Menteith in the Center's production of *MACBETH*, which deepened her love for classical theatre. Emily is thrilled to make her Limelight Theatre debut in Eugène Ionesco's *RHINOCEROS*, a thought-provoking play exploring themes of conformity and individuality. Passionate about storytelling, both on and off the stage, Emily aspires to be a playwright and hopes to create works that challenge perspectives and connect with audiences. Whether performing or writing, she is dedicated to exploring the complexities of human emotion through theatre.

Outside of rehearsals, she enjoys time with her family—including her older brother, three cats, two dogs, and a bird—all of whom add a little extra excitement to her life. Emily is deeply grateful to her parents for their constant support and encouragement. She looks forward to continuing her journey as both an actress and writer, bringing meaningful stories to life and inspiring others through the performing arts.

Alberto C. Peart



Alberto Carlos (Berenger) is honored to portray Berenger in *RHINOCEROS* at Limelight Theatre. His theatre credits include *HAMLET* (King Claudius), *ANTIGONE* (Haemon), and *SPRING AWAKENING*. He has worked with A Classic Theatre and Crime and Merriment Productions, and has appeared in numerous film and television projects, including *GREEK* (ABC Family) and *THE 11TH HOUR* (CBS). Beyond the stage, Alberto is a dedicated content creator and educator, working with students with disabilities in theatre

and media arts in St. Augustine. He is passionate about storytelling, digital media, and empowering young artists to find their creative voice. He studied Media Arts at Westfield State College and trained in physical theatre, movement, and ballroom dance with institutions such as Shakespeare & Company (Lenox, MA), The Drama Studio, and Serious Play! Theatre Ensemble. As a writer and director, Alberto's original works include *I, HOPE*, a play exploring the treatment of persons with disabilities throughout history. He extends heartfelt gratitude to the cast, crew, and Limelight Theatre for bringing this production to life—and to the audience for supporting live theatre.

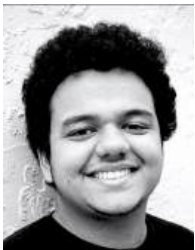
Cast

Megan Rodriguez



Megan (Housewife with Cat/Music Director) is a performer, musician, and teaching artist who loves sharing her passion for the arts. Her recent credits include Doralee in 9 TO 5 and Felicity in the UCF Project Spotlight one-act *SO LONG, PARTNER*. When she's not on stage, Megan teaches with Limelight's KidzFACTory, offers private piano and voice lessons, and studies Music Education at the University of Central Florida. She is thrilled to be back and deeply grateful to the cast, crew, her family, and her partner for their constant support.

Anthony Romero



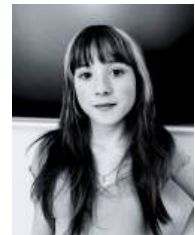
This will be Anthony's (Grocer/Fireman) fourth time in a show here at the Limelight. He has recently been seen as Gangster #2 in *THE DROWSY CHAPERONE*. Anthony is very excited to be a part of this show, since this will be the first straight play that he has been a part of. Anthony has always been a part of the arts since he was little with activities, such as dance and chorus. It wasn't until after high school that he found his love for musical theatre. This show will be a major step in Anthony's growth as an artist.

Charles Ross



Charles (Proprietor/Fireman) is a Retired Army and Marine Corps Veteran with over 26 years of service. He has been involved in community theatre for over 40 years, and has worked with the First Coast Opera, Flagler Playhouse, and River City Players, as well as the Limelight Theatre, both in performing and set construction. He most recently performed as Colonel Brandon in *SENSE AND SENSIBILITY*.

Hannah Schaefer



With *RHINOCEROS*, Hannah (Logician) is appearing in her second Limelight production, following *THE BEST CHRISTMAS PAGEANT EVER*. She has also performed in *MADAGASCAR JR*. Hannah's passion for the stage is evident, and she strives to bring depth and intelligence to every role. In addition to acting, Hannah is a violinist and an avid reader.

Crew

Mary Claire Branton



Mary Claire (Director) earned a BA in Theatre from the University of Georgia and an MFA in Acting from Brooklyn College. She studied Chekhov and Stanislavsky with the Moscow Art Theatre and workshopped Anne Bogart's Viewpoints at Columbia University. In 2008, Mary Claire directed *WAITING FOR MY GROWTH SPURT* at Atlanta's Woodruff Arts Center, a play written and performed by a twelve-year-old, which sold out and is considered one of the first professional one-kid shows in the U.S. Her absurdist direction of Kyle Jarrow's Obie Award-winning *A VERY MERRY UNAUTHORIZED CHILDREN'S SCIENTOLOGY PAGEANT* also sold out two

years in a row at Dad's Garage Theatre and was named one of the top 10 shows in Atlanta by *Creative Loafing* in 2007. Mary Claire has taught acting and directed at numerous educational institutions and professional theatres across America, with cast sizes as large as 96 children.

She is passionate about pioneering new genres of expression where adults and children collaborate to create barrier-breaking material aimed at specific audiences. Mary Claire spent two years leading extracurricular drama programs in China at the Taihu International School and the International School of Wuxi near Shanghai. She also spent several years as an editor and publisher of books by child authors and illustrators, with several titles winning literary awards. Before joining the three-ring circus that is Limelight Theatre, Mary Claire worked as a ghostwriter in the literary marketplace, focusing on the true-crime and inspirational genres. She is a member of The Author's Guild.

Jamie Bullins



Jamie Bullins (Costume Designer) is an associate professor in the Johnny Carson School of Theatre and Film at the University of Nebraska–Lincoln. Throughout his career, he has contributed as a designer, director, and playwright to over 100 projects with numerous prestigious companies, including Angels Theatre Company, The Nebraska Repertory Theatre, The Rose Theatre, The Alliance Theatre, Theatrical Outfit, The Center for Puppetry Arts, Dad's Garage Theatre, Georgia Ensemble Theatre, The Aurora Theatre,

True Colors Theatre, Connecticut Theatre Festival, Bloomsburg Theatre Ensemble, The Abingdon Theatre, and The Irondale Ensemble Project. As the years accumulate, reflecting on the body of work can feel daunting, but Jamie remains deeply grateful for the opportunities to tell these stories. He continues to believe in the power of theatre to change people. Fool.

Olive Ferreira



Olive Ferreira (Makeup Design) is an upcoming senior at St. Augustine High School and a proud member of their St. Johns County Center for the Arts program. She began exploring special effects makeup for her school's production of *MACBETH* and is thrilled to continue her work in this area at Limelight Theatre. Outside of behind-the-scenes work, Olive also loves being on stage and has appeared in productions such as *PETER AND THE STAR CATCHER* and *PUFFS* at her high school. She is excited to be involved in another Limelight show and can't wait to see the final result!

Crew

Audrey Hoffman



Audrey (Assistant Director) is so grateful for the opportunity to assistant direct this beautifully absurd production of *RHINOCEROS*. She was last seen on Limelight's main stage as Margaret in *SENSE AND SENSIBILITY*. Audrey is a junior at Saint Augustine High School, where she studies chorus, theatre, and musical theatre in the Saint Johns County Center for the Arts program. She would like to thank her director, Mary Claire, for trusting her with such an important role on the production team and for the opportunity

to work with and learn from such incredibly talented artists.

From the Assistant Director:

If you had told me a few months ago that I'd be assistant directing the absurdist French play, *Rhinoceros*, I probably would've laughed at you. Joining this team wasn't something I planned. Our phenomenal director, Mary Claire, pulled me aside before a *Sense and Sensibility* rehearsal and asked me, "What do you want to do for Limelight?"

One conversation led to another, and suddenly I found myself in a rehearsal room with a script in hand, sitting across from grown adults asking for direction from a 17 year-old junior in high school. However, from the very first rehearsal, I knew this was exactly where I was supposed to be. Watching this group of actors play with the psychological aspects of Ionesco's writing, and working with them to create these beautiful layers of emotion, was truly an experience I will never forget. Not to mention, the technical team worked mind-blowing magic that I never had the chance to study as an actor.

I learned so much, not just about theatre, but about leadership, communication, and trusting my own voice. This experience may have started spontaneously, but now it feels like fate. I would like to thank the entire team for supporting and working with me to create this brilliant piece of theatre, and director Mary Claire for trusting me with such a strong position in the creative process. And thank you, the audience, for stepping into this world with us. I hope our production of *Rhinoceros* leaves you curious, uplifted, and most of all unsettled.

"Art should comfort the disturbed and disturb the comfortable." - Cesar A. Cruz



Crew



Melissa “Millie” McKinney



Melissa’s (Stage Manager) journey began in high school, where she studied theatre, band, and tech in Houston, TX. Over the last two decades, she has worked as an event coordinator, producing countless concerts, large art and music festivals, and destination weddings across the nation. With a strong emphasis on the visual and performing arts throughout her career, Melissa toured as Stage Manager for the Lagunitas Beer Circus, served as

Assistant Art Director for Lacy Maxwell Experiential during the infamous South by Southwest in Austin, TX, and has performed as a featured poet during tri-coastal tours. In 2012, Melissa was the supporting actress in Italian Director and Screenwriter Roberto Minervini’s film *LOW TIDE*, which made its world debut at the 69th International Venice Film Festival. The film won the Christopher D. Smithers Foundation Special Award, was nominated for the Venice Horizons Award, and was showcased at the International Film Festival Rotterdam and Viennale.

Rod Morris



Rod (Properties Master) is a project manager by day, but a theatre enthusiast at heart! With a background in acting in various high school and community theatre productions, he was thrilled for the opportunity to serve as Props Master for this production. Rod embraces the challenge of finding, borrowing, or building just the right prop for each scene. Getting to collaborate with such talented local theatre professionals has been a true highlight—icing on the cake. Break a leg, cast!

Rob O’Leary



Robert (Set Designer) has been designing and building scenery for over 38 years. Local theatre patrons may be familiar with his work at Florida School of the Arts, where he served as a professor and head of Scenic and Lighting Design for 14 years. Robert is happy to be designing for Limelight Theatre once again, having previously designed productions such as *SWEET BIRD OF YOUTH*, *BIG FISH*, *THE DIVINERS*, *LITTLE MISS SUNSHINE*, *WAIT UNTIL DARK*, and *MEMOIRS OF A FORGOTTEN MAN*.

Day Stanchi



Day is a high school senior and has been involved with Limelight Theatre for seven years. Most recently, she served as stage manager and sound designer for CRIMES OF THE HEART, stage manager, lighting designer, and props coordinator for ALICE IN WONDERLAND JR., and props coordinator and light & sound board operator for THE BEST CHRISTMAS PAGEANT EVER, THE MUSICAL, JV. She is very excited and grateful for the opportunity to work with Michael Takita and Mary Claire on RHINOCEROS.

Michael Takita



Michael (Lighting Designer) is originally from Maui and has lived in California and France before recently relocating to St. Augustine, where he is excited to become a member of the Limelight Theatre family. Michael has been involved in theatre since his high school years and has since retired from his position as Director of Information Technology at a prominent CPA firm in California. He has worked as a lighting designer for numerous organizations, including Maui Academy of Performing Arts, Maui Onstage, and Tihati Productions, among others.

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